

BSIS Program Review Essay

My time in the Bachelor of Science in Information Science program with a concentration in Web Development Technologies has been a very interesting mix of learning, figuring things out, and honestly just trying to understand where this degree fits in the real world. When I changed majors, I had never heard of Information Science so I was very unclear of what I could even do with this degree. I learned a lot of different things throughout the program though, like web design, interaction design, information architecture, communication, and even some security and networking concepts. Some of it was useful and gave me a better understanding of technology and how information works, but I also felt like a lot of the classes were very information heavy and didn't always feel actually useful or transferable to the real world in any relevant careers. This was one of the biggest things I struggled with throughout this program, because I kept wondering how everything connected to the careers I was interested in and a lot of the times, there seemed to be no connection.

Even though this program wasn't all great for me, some of the classes did leave a memorable mark with me; like the ones that had the most connection to web development and user experience. Courses like LIS 3361 WWW Page Design/Management, LIS 3352 Interaction Design, LIS 3783 Information Architecture (which I am currently taking), and LIS 4365 Web Design Technologies were some of the most memorable and useful for me because they felt like they matched my concentration and the kind of work I could actually see myself doing. These classes helped me understand how websites are built, how content should be organized, and how design affects the way users interact with a site. I also think LIS 4029 Professional and Technical Communication for Analysts (another one that I am currently taking) is helpful because learning how to communicate clearly is very important no matter what career you choose to go into. Even though I did learn a lot from these classes, I do still feel like some of them could have done a better job of connecting the lessons to real career skills and showing us what those jobs actually look like.

Some of the assignments I have done in this program had more of an impact on me than others. In Information Architecture, for example, I spent a lot of time building both low-fidelity and high-fidelity wireframes. That process made me think more like a designer and really pay attention to layout, hierarchy, and how users move through a page or a system. It was one of the first times I could clearly see what I was doing in a class connected to real UX and UI work. In WWW Page Design/Management, my Project 1 was a big moment for me because it was the first time I actually built my own website from scratch and fell in love with web development. Stylesheets totally confused me at first, and I struggled to understand them just from the old videos that were being uploaded by the professor, so I ended up having to find multiple other resources to help me better understand what I was supposed to be learning. I ran into many issues like my menu not showing up or disappearing after clicking a link, and I spent a lot of time trying to figure out what was wrong in my code. Eventually I realized it was a styling issue and not what I originally thought, and even though it took longer than I wanted, it felt really good

when I finally got it to work the way I wanted it to. That project showed me what it actually feels like to debug a real problem and not just follow a step-by-step tutorial. In Professional and Technical Communication for Analysts, a lot of the focus has been on grammar, editing, and clear writing. Going through grammar reviews and feedback made me realize that my grammar is not as strong as I thought it was, and it really opened my eyes and made me realize that I need to pay more attention to how I write and how I come across professionally. Even though that was a little humbling, it is actually really useful, because almost any job I go into will expect me to write emails, reports, or documentation that are clear and professional.

One of the biggest things I noticed throughout this program is that I constantly wasn't feeling like I was properly being prepared for any type of career and more so just strictly learning about information. I think the program gave me a good foundation, but I still have to figure out a lot on my own when it comes to understanding what kind of jobs I could even go for. I've applied to analytics, web development, and UI/UX roles, but I still feel unsure about how qualified I really am for those positions. A lot of the courses taught me how to work with information, organize it, and understand different systems, but I wish there had been more focus on using those skills in ways that felt directly connected to actual jobs or at least mention different jobs that we could do that these skills would be useful for. That is probably the part that was most frustrating for me, because I wanted the program to feel more practical and career focused.

For me, the most beneficial part of this whole experience actually came from outside the BSIS program through the Career Accelerator program. That experience was the closest thing I had to real world preparation, and it helped me in a way that the classes alone did not. It gave me hands on experience, real projects, showed me how what I was learning can be used in actual work and gave me a chance to see what an actual work environment is like. That was really important for me because it helped me understand what it feels like to work on something that matters outside of school. It also helped me see how class knowledge can be used in a professional setting, which made the transition from college to career feel more real.

I also think the Career Accelerator helped me build confidence. It showed me that I can work on professional tasks, manage expectations, and complete projects that feel similar to what I might do in a real job. That kind of experience is what I feel like I needed most, because it gave me a better idea of how to move forward after graduation. The BSIS program gave me a lot of background knowledge, but the Career Accelerator helped me connect that knowledge to actual work. It made everything feel more meaningful because I could finally see how some of the things I learned might be used in a real career.

Actually, that is the biggest thing I think this program was missing, hands on experience. This whole program is completely online; a lot of the lectures and assignments are just recycled from covid (5-6 years ago). It's like there's no effort put into keeping the academic material updated. A lot has changed in 5-6 years, our material should've changed, we should be learning

to work with new technology, and the course should be changing with the times. For example, one of the big things I learned in the career accelerator was how to properly use AI in the real world/in my career because AI here and AI is the future. But not once in any of my classes was AI mentioned outside of just don't use it. AI is one of the biggest technological advancements we've had in the past 5-6 years since covid, especially in this major that's so technologically reliant, AI should be a big thing that we should be learning about and interacting with.

Overall, I think the BSIS program helped me learn a lot, even if it did not always feel like it was preparing me as directly as I wanted. I now have a better understanding of web development, information studies, and some of the skills that matter in technology related careers. At the same time, I also learned that hands-on experience is what really helped me grow the most. The Career Accelerator program was the most valuable part of my journey because it gave me practical experience and helped me feel more prepared for life after college. Even though I still have questions about what exactly I can do with this degree and what career path I want to take, this program and my outside experience both helped me move closer to figuring that out.